SPORTS INFORMATION DIRECTORS AND DON'T ASK, DON'T TELL NARRATIVES:

Applying Gatekeeping Theory to the Creation and Contents of Division I Women's Basketball Online Coaching Biographies

BACKGROUND

Research consistently shows how gay and lesbian coaches respond to homophobia with silence, especially when it comes to including family narratives in public settings. Scholars speculate as to why this silence exists from two antipodal approaches: self-policing and institutionalized policing (Krane & Kauer, 2013; Norman, 2012). While we know that coaches respond with silence narratives (i.e., don't tell) when it comes to same-sex family narratives, it is unclear what dialogues (i.e., don't ask) occur between sports information directors (SIDs) and coaches with regard to including same-sex family narratives in online coaching biographies

FRAMEWORK

Gatekeeping Theory is useful to assess and analyze how and why certain pieces of information pass through "gates" and other pieces of information are rejected. In abstracting Gatekeeping Theory, Shoemaker & Vos (2009) created five levels of study: (a) the individual communication workers (i.e., individuals' attitudes or gender); (b) the routines or practices of communication work (i.e., deadlines or editing routines); (c) the organization level (i.e., the athletic department); (d) the social institutional level of analysis (i.e., influence from the university, boosters, or community); (e) the social system level (i.e., variables like ideology and culture).

PURPOSE STATEMENT

It was the aim of this research to identify explanations for the absence of same-sex narratives in online coaching biographies from the point of view of sports information directors (SIDs) using Gatekeeping Theory as an guiding framework.

Thus, the purpose of this research was to explore how and why, from the perspective and experience of the SID, same-sex family narratives get masked and erased in online coaching biographies using semi-structured interviews as the data collection mechanism.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

(1) What communication routines exist when sports information directors create online coaching biographies of Division I women's basketball coaches?

(2) Besides communication routines, what gatekeeping factors (individual, organizational, institutional, or social system) influence the creation of online coaching biographies of Division I women's basketball coaches?

(3) What explanations do sports information directors offer for the absence of non-traditional family narratives in online coaching biographies of Division I women's basketball coaches?

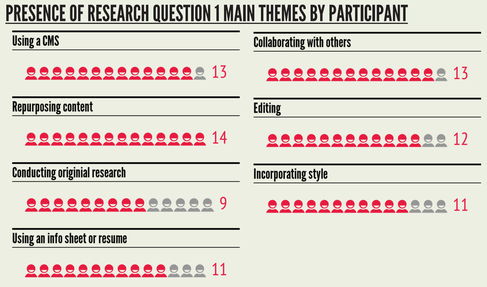
METHODOLOGY

This research employed a qualitative approach, specifically critical discourse analysis. Semi-structured short form phone interviews were used to collect information related to the creation of online coaching biographies and the explanations for the absence of same-sex narratives from Division I BCS women's basketball sports information directors who represent a female head coach. The inital population for this project was the sports information director supporting those 45 programs (N = 45), while the sample represented nearly a third of the total poulation (n = 14).

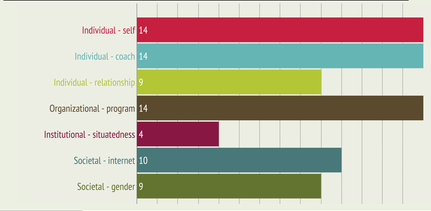
RESULTS

Major findings were trifold: (1) SIDs presented similar communication routines when creating online coaching biographies, (2) each level of Gatekeeping Theory was reflected the content in online coaching biographies, and (3) SIDs explained the absence of same-sex narratives by placing the blame elsewhere and absolving themselves.

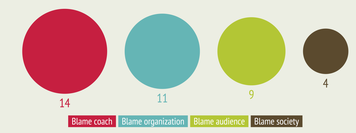
PRESENCE OF RESEARCH QUESTION 1 MAIN THEMES BY PARTICIPANT



PRESENCE OF RESEARCH QUESTION 2 MAIN THEMES BY PARTICIPANT



PRESENCE OF RESEARCH QUESTION 3 MAIN THEMES BY PARTICIPANT



Presence of Research Question 3 "Blame Game" Themes by Participant



Participants' Responses Representing the Absolution Devolution

DISCUSSION

The results of this resesearch show how Gatekeeping Theory is an applicable framework for considering the creation of online coaching biographies and the absence of same-sex family narratives in the medium. The reasons SIDs *don't ask* parallel the levels of Gatekeeping Theory. The results of this research provide data that SIDs are complicit actors in this process–**they help self-police, they police themselves, and they reinforce institutionalized and administrative policing.** When it comes to family narratives, SIDs participate in a surveillance function that values and promotes conventional arrangement and hides and protects perceived deviance. The results demonstrate that SIDs perceive a same-sex narrative as a threat and make conscious and unconscious decisions to provide protection to coaches, players, programs, and audiences. This research also furnishes information about that moment, process, and content. **The results make it appears not only do SIDs not "ask" coaches if they want to include their same-sex family narratives, SIDs also do not think they could or should broach the subject.**

With the potential to affect stakeholders and constituents in sport and LBGT communities, this project gives a voice to SIDs, while also raising their attention to a serious issue. The most practical implication of this research is that SIDs will ask a gay or lesbian coach if they want to include their partner included in their biography. Additional practical implication would be neutralizing any heterosexist language that exists in school forms that coaches fill out. **Future research should address how SIDs can neutralize their routines and offer opportunities for inclusion of same-sex family narratives in online coaching biographies.**

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